

Why Does Tongues Build Us Up

Now that we know praying in tongues somehow helps us mortify the deeds of the body, and we know it edifies us and charges us up on our most holy faith, the question is: how?

This is the basics of prayer. How does it do it? How does you and I sitting in our chairs, walking back and forth in our living rooms, standing in the front of an auditorium, or circling the auditorium, praying in tongues hour after hour, increase anyone's faith?

I have asked God this: "How does speaking a bunch of syllables into the air increase anybody's faith? Do I have to interpret every phrase of tongues that I speak out of my spirit?"

No.

"Can I pray in tongues hour after hour and still receive the edification, even though I am not interpreting, per se, each sentence of tongues?"

Yes, you can.

The question is, how does praying in tongues build you up on your most holy faith? I asked God this many times in the past.

So I went to those who seemed to be somewhat among them, and I said, "Why does praying in tongues edify me? Why does it charge me up like a battery?"

Most of the time, they would proceed to break down the word "edify" in the Greek.

"Well, Brother Roberson, don't you know what the word edify means?"

I said, "Yes. It means to build yourself up."

"Well, a proper translation would be, 'The nice man took the battery down to the gas station and edified it.'"

I thought, When I am praying in tongues, you mean I am receiving a charge, a tangible charge like a battery receives?

For a long time, I accepted that third-grade explanation. I will tell you why. After spending about half a year in prayer, I went into some of my first meetings and laid hands on a woman. She fell out under the power, and I thought, My God. Negative, positive. Positive. In Jesus' name, 220 volts, woman.

So I ignorantly believed that the more I prayed in tongues, the more I was receiving some kind of substance-charge on the inside of my spirit that would be released when I laid negative and positive on each side of your head. It must have been true: people were getting healed, and people were falling on the floor. I thought, This is a pretty good sign.

Then others said, "Don't you know what the word edify means? It means to build an edifice, a superstructure."

An edifice is a superstructure created or built to house something. So when you pray in tongues, you are creating a superstructure, an edifice, on the inside of your spirit to house the anointing of God.

But the question remains: why does praying in tongues construct this edifice to house the anointing of God? Why and how does speaking syllables into the air charge anybody up on their most holy faith?

If there is one area where the Church is confused, it is the issue of speaking with tongues. If there is any area that has turned the church world off, it is speaking with tongues. The reason is that we have abused it because we have not understood it.

About the time you talk one of your friends into coming to church, after working on them for two months, they come and sit in the back row. They happen to sit next to Sister Holy Ghost, and right on cue she lets out a scream. Their hair goes up, and pretty soon she is chicken-walking across the front.

Do you know what chicken-walking is? Have you ever seen a chicken walk? They can walk. Have you ever seen a Pentecostal chicken-walker?

Now you have this poor, ignorant person sitting on the back row watching this woman scream. They are thinking, My God, what is going on? They turn to you and say, "What is going on?"

You say, "Oh, the Holy Ghost is on her."

"Who?"

"God is on her."

"Why did she scream?"

"That was the anointing."

"Why is her neck jerking?"

"She is feeling the anointing. How would you like to receive the Holy Ghost?"

"Oh no, thank you. I was at a chiropractor last month, and he said I have damage in this disc."

How do you think that looks to the world?

I used to think I would know the Holy Ghost when I got to heaven. I would know God: He is the nice-looking Gentleman on the throne with the liquid power flowing out of Him. I know who He is. Then Jesus, who would not know Him? Eyes like pools of compassion. He looks through you. I know who He is.

But who is that finely dressed Gentleman standing behind Jesus? All of a sudden, the third Person in the Godhead steps up with His hand extended and says, "[tongues]."

I say, "It is the Holy Ghost. I can tell by Your accent. Good grief, I remember Your voice on earth."

I used to wonder why preachers did that. They seemed normal otherwise. "How are the children?" "Oh, they are fine." "How is the missus?" "Oh, she is doing great." "Well, I have to go preach now." "All right, I am coming to listen tonight."

Then they get up and say, "We are taking our text from 1 Corinthians 14:1. Dear God, I bless this Word. Thank You." Then they go, "Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts..." And I think, What happened?

I said, "Why do you do that?"

"Well, that is the anointing. The anointing is on me."

Funny, He does not make me act like that. Kathryn Kuhlman did not do that, and who can say she did not have the anointing?

I asked God, "Why do they do that?"

He said, "That is their reaction to the anointing."

So is chicken-walking. But you do not have to. You can screw your neck on tighter and just sit there. I do not mind hot-rodding, yelling, shouting, and running around. I just do not like to go spastic.

In the early days, men were preaching machines. They preached to 10,000 people with no microphones. They would yell at the sinner on the back row, "You on the back row, if you leave here tonight, you will die anyway!" It scared hell out of them, and a lot of them came to God. They would preach all their wind out.

Then came the generation with microphones, and they thought that was the anointing. "Do not hand me that slobbery mic."

I said, "God, I have to know why I am edified. You gave us such a precious gift as the Holy Spirit and praying in tongues. There must be a whole lot more to this than we understand. It certainly was not designed to turn people off."

But the devil likes to get in and mess everything up. By the time he is done with tongues, most of us do not want to use them.

Some say, "I can only pray in tongues when I am emotional, when I am in a church service and the Holy Ghost is moving heavily on me. Then all of a sudden something comes out."

"Do you mean the only time you can pray in tongues is when you are emotional and crying?"

"Yes."

Give me a baseball bat.

I said, "My Father, why are we edified? Why are we edified from praying in tongues hour after hour? What makes the difference in our lives?"

Notice the first verse very closely:

Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy.

When Paul said, "rather that ye may prophesy," he was exhorting the entire Corinthian church, as individual believers, to desire and seek God until they came to a place spiritually where they edified the whole Body. He was not saying prophecy is more important than praying in tongues. In a collective sense, for the good of the whole Church, you need to seek God to excel, to come to a place where He can use you in prophecy.

So he says, "Follow after charity," which is love in action, "and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy."

Then he says:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

Notice this closely. He that speaks in an unknown tongue speaks not to men, but to God.

When I am praying in tongues for personal edification, I am not talking to you. I am talking to God. He says, "He speaketh not unto men, but unto God." So why do you think you can yell tongues at the devil? You are yelling at God and do not know it. I assure you, God is not deaf. In fact, He is right there with you if you can receive it.

He says that the person praying in an unknown tongue speaks not to men, but to God, for no man understands him. If I speak in my prayer language, you do not understand it because it was not designed to be understood by you. This is tongues for personal edification. There is only One who understands it, and that is my Father God.

Then Paul uses an analytical word and clarifies the whole thing for us: "Howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries."

If I am praying with tongues and I do not understand myself, and you do not understand me, and this is not a tongue to be interpreted, then who is understanding me? God is. What is happening in the realm of the Spirit? Paul answers: in the Spirit, this man speaks mysteries.

When I am praying in tongues for personal edification, that is only one of four different diversities of tongues God uses through us. This is why Jude 20 says you can build yourself up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost. Notice he did not say only "praying in tongues for personal edification." Praying in the Holy Ghost covers the whole spectrum of Spirit-empowered prayer.

There are four diversities. If you try to govern all four diversities of tongues by the same set of rules, you will end up confused, like many Pentecostal churches that never broke into the power of God.

The first diversity is tongues for personal edification. That is the one you talk to God with.

The second diversity is tongues that present themselves in a public assembly for the sole purpose of interpretation: tongues for interpretation.

The third diversity is tongues that extend into the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit and empower you to stand in the gap for your life, your family, your city, and your nation before God. That is when God literally picks you up by the nape of the neck, bends you, and puts you on a path between sinners and hell. You are blocking their entry into hell. It is a powerful gift. But the rules that govern deep intercessional groanings are as different from tongues for interpretation as night is from day, and they are different from the rules that govern tongues for personal edification.

The fourth diversity is tongues that present themselves as a sign to the unbeliever. That one is the most unusual of all. It has come on me nine times in my ministry, mostly overseas. That is when the Holy Spirit suddenly comes upon you and begins to create a language on the inside of you. When you speak it out of your mouth, it bypasses your intelligence and allows you to testify, preach, or speak in a language on the face of this earth that you had no previous knowledge of.

Let me put it this way. You are in Germany. They only speak German. Your translator suddenly has a heart attack and falls on the floor. He is the only English-German-speaking gentleman in the crowd. You are staring at a group of German-speaking people, and you only speak English.

You have a choice. You can pull down a major gift of the Spirit, the working of miracles, and say, "Nobody gets out of my service that easily," raise him from the dead, and say, "Now would you kindly finish translating? Thank you. For God so loved the world..."

Or you may yield yourself to the Holy Spirit. If this diversity moves through you, suddenly you will hear yourself preaching the entire message in German. Nine times out of ten, you will not know a thing you are saying, but those people will enjoy that message better than any you have ever preached. Generally, the whole crowd will move down front and prostrate themselves in salvation. That, my friend, is a sign to the unbeliever personified.

That has happened to me nine times. I base it on the fact that my spirit is edified from spending much time in the first diversity, talking to God out of my supernatural language.

The last time it happened to me was at a camp meeting with Bill Basansky. Bill speaks Russian, and so does his mother. I had taught that night. All of a sudden, I broke out worshipping and praising God, making whole statements of praise in Russian. Bill dragged me into the back room, looked at me, and said, "Do you speak Russian?"

I said, "No."

"Do you speak any other language?"

I said, "Only broken English."

He said, "You were praising God in complete phrases in Russian and glorifying Him."

I thought, Oh my God.

But we do not need to concern ourselves much with that gift. You can concern yourself with edifying yourself in the one Paul is talking about when he says, "He that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God."

You are talking to God. Your spirit has entered into an intimate relationship with Him. It is the ultimate closet experience. You go into the holiest of holies, slam the door behind you, and your spirit is locked into fellowship with God's Spirit. You are communicating directly with the Father in a supernatural language out of your spirit.

I know speaking with tongues edifies me. I know it charges me up like a battery and builds a superstructure on the inside of my spirit. But the question is still: how? Why? How does speaking syllables into the air, which my own mind does not understand, edify me?

First Corinthians 14 says:

For if I pray in an unknown tongue, my spirit prayeth, but my understanding is unfruitful.

Here I am praying this language, and the whole church world has asked us, "Why do you do it?"

We have not been able to give sufficient answers.

"What is the difference between you and us who do not speak with tongues?"

"Well, we are Pentecostal."

"I know that. We do not speak with tongues. You do. Why do you do it?"

"Well, it charges us up like a battery."

"Really? How does it do that?"

"It builds us up on our most holy faith."

"But you told me faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God. Do you understand what you are praying?"

"No."

"Then how does it build you up on your faith?"

"Because the Word of God says it edifies me."

"How does it do that?"

"It charges me up like a battery."

"How?"

"It builds me up on my most holy faith."

"What are you saying?"

"I do not know, unless He gives me the interpretation."

"Then why do it if there is no interpretation?"

"Because He said it would edify me."

"How?"

"I do not know. Can't you just take it by faith?"

"How can I? You said faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word."

So we have been confused too.

That one word "howbeit" is analytical. How is this? We are talking in tongues, but not the diversity that is interpreted. We are talking to God. No man understands us. Yet Paul says it builds us up on our most holy faith and edifies us. How?

What is really transpiring in the realm of the Spirit when you are praying in tongues? Paul says, "Howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries."

This is what I like to do when trouble comes or an evil report comes: I immediately put myself in the Spirit, because Paul says, "Howbeit in the spirit this man speaketh mysteries."

I knew that if I could break down and understand what he meant by mysteries, I could understand why we experience such a tremendous increase of faith from praying in the Holy Ghost.

The word mysteries means divine secrets. It means that which is out of the range of unassisted natural apprehension and can be made known only by divine intervention. That is a mystery.

And I am speaking mysteries. That which is out of the range of unassisted natural apprehension and can be made known only by divine intervention, my Father has freed me to speak in tongues as much as I please, hour after hour, bringing these divine secrets and mysteries before Him.

I knew my answer lay in dissecting the meaning of this word. If you think I did not get Greek books, interlinears, outlines, Wuest, Strong's, and every other tool I could find, take that word apart, and put it back together, I did. I wanted to know why and what mysteries Paul was talking about.

Do you want to know what I found? He is talking about the same Greek rendering as the mysteries that had been hid in God since before the foundation of the world, but now have been made available to the great Church of God in this dispensation of grace: the mystery of Christ in you, the hope of glory.

My God.

You mean I cannot pray one hour in tongues, speaking mysteries, without praying up before the throne of grace some aspect of spiritual understanding, some apprehension in the Spirit, some aspect of what Christ through the Cross is in me, the hope of glory? My friend, these mysteries are the same mysteries Paul said he had been made a minister of, the manifold wisdom and mysteries of Christ.

How could Paul minister a mystery unless he had first come into the understanding of what he was ministering? And Paul had the audacity to boast to the entire Corinthian church, every man, woman, and child:

I thank my God, I speak with tongues more than ye all.

Was he amusing himself? No. In church, he said, "I would rather instruct you in five words of understanding than ten thousand words to God that you do not understand." But outside the church, he said, "I thank my God that I speak with tongues more than you all."

Let's talk further about these mysteries: Christ in you, the hope of glory. Christ through you and to you, the hope of glory. Christ in you, to you, and through you, the hope of glory.

The mysteries you speak in tongues are Christ in you, to you, and through you, the hope of glory.

These mysteries you are speaking before God hour after hour in the Holy Ghost are not for God's benefit. What divine secret are you going to sneak up on His blind side and whisper in His ear that He did not know a couple of millennia before you came along?

The mysteries and divine secrets you are praying in the Holy Ghost, even though you do not understand them, are not meant for God's benefit. You are not going to tell Him some deep, dark secret He did not know long before you arrived. He knows everything about you. He knows your problems. He knows what causes your problems. He knows how to walk you out of them. He knows how to send you to feeding stations where they will feed you out of them. He knows how important it is to gather together, pray together, learn together, fight the devil together, and hold each other up.

He knows.

These mysteries are not for God's benefit, my friend. They are for your benefit.

Therefore, praying in tongues is like any other kind of prayer. The mighty prayer of faith moves mountains. The prayer of consecration says, "Lord, if it be Your will, if You want me to go to China, I will go to China. If You want me to go to Russia, I will go to Russia." There is the prayer of commitment, the prayer of love, the prayer of the Spirit, intercession, supplication.

Praying in tongues is like any other kind of prayer: it is not designed to go unanswered. It is designed to be answered. But the way God answers it is as unique as anything He has ever done.

Here is how He answers it.

We may mentally assent to a verse for ten years. "Oh God, if I could ever cleave to this verse. Surely He has borne my sicknesses and carried my pains. I could get this cancer off my body. I could get these lumps out of my body." But that verse can reside in our intellect for ten years. As many attempts as we make against disease and for healing, we cannot seem to get it out of our head and into our heart.

Do you want to know the function of mysteries?

He that searcheth the hearts knoweth what is the mind of the Spirit, because He maketh intercession for the saints according to the will of God.

The Holy Spirit knows what your problem is. When you pray in tongues, He is searching your heart and praying God's will down on you concerning that problem. If cancer or poverty is killing you, my friend, would you not consider that a problem?

Picture Paul with his staff, walking along. Of course, I travel with another kind of staff now: helps and associates. His was wood.

I can see Paul walking along with Timothy trailing behind him, praying in tongues as he goes. Pretty soon Timothy hears him muttering.

"What did you say, Paul?"

"I am not talking to you. I am talking to God."

Mile after mile, he prays. That night he pitches his tent. They have been walking three days, and he is lying by the lamp praying in tongues. All of a sudden the Holy Ghost says, "You know those mysteries you have been praying up for the last hundred miles?"

"Yes, Sir."

"These are mysteries of Christ in you, the hope of glory."

"Yes, Sir."

"I am ready to answer that prayer."

All of a sudden those mysteries begin feeding through his spirit. He says, "Oh my God."

The Spirit says, "I want you to write this to the Romans."

Paul gets his quill, dips it, and starts writing that mystery down.

"Now send this to the Roman church."

He continues to pray.

"Now send this to the Colossians. Now the Ephesians. The Galatians. The Corinthians."

All these mysteries he has been praying, he starts writing down.

The reason you are edified from praying in tongues is that you have a copy of the original mysteries that set the canon of Scripture, the doctrine of Jesus Christ in you, the hope of glory. It is sitting in your lap. You read across some of those things and think, I do not understand them. That is because you do not have a foundation.

But you start praying in tongues, and you pray the mysteries recorded there. God says, "I am ready to answer in that verse you have had lodged in your mind for ten years concerning healing."

Then suddenly the mystery opens. My God. Do you know He bore my sicknesses and carried my pains? You get so excited about it that the disease leaves your body.

Because you, beloved, build yourself up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

When John G. Lake came out from Dowie's ministry, Dowie had the city of Zion. In the days when people traveled by horse, buggy, and train to meetings, at the turn of the century, he had 10,000 in attendance at Zion. Ten thousand, when people walked or came by horse and buggy.

Do you want to know why? When John G. Lake met up with Dowie's ministry, three invalids in Lake's family were healed. Three invalids in one family under one man's anointing. It so affected John G. Lake that it launched him into a healing ministry.

They later got hold of Lake's notes that he made throughout his life. For a while, they did not even put one page in the book they published. Eventually I saw they had included it, but early on I found that page and said, "Thank God. Somebody else is preaching this."

John G. Lake said, "I want to speak with the utmost frankness concerning that peculiar language of tongues that I mostly speak in the nighttime. I have found it to be not only the source of power that I operate in on a day-by-day basis, but also an invaluable source of revelation knowledge that I preach every day."

John G. Lake had so many recorded cases of miracles in Spokane that it almost turned Spokane around. They could have five terminal diseases in a clinical room, and he would lay hands on them for five days. Three would walk out instantly, one would recover in time, and that was his average. We have nothing like it today.

These men attributed it to the walk of the Spirit.

My friend, I am all for the organization of helps and governments because it is in the Body, and many of you are called to such things. I am all for organization, for soul-winning programs, visitation, and all these things.

But when you start replacing your responsibility for the power of God with organizational concepts, then when you get people here, what are you going to do with them?

God wants to meet their needs on both ends. He wants helps and governments that will knock your skin off, that will take care of the tiniest little born-again believer on the outskirts of a massive operation, so that everything he needs filters down through the Body and supplies it. But He also wants a devastating move of power to flow through the services, meeting the people's needs.

You cannot throw away that responsibility.

If you think all we are going to do is learn prayer, and you think this is all there is to it, that you will come in here, sit under preaching, and be sent out in programs, you have another thought coming.

I am going to harass you until you pray enough to turn yourself over to the Holy Spirit, until you are consumed with God and consumed with revival. One of the hardest things to purge is dead complacency, dead indifference, and dead consumability. It has to die until you are consumed with God, consumed with this generation being lost, and consumed with revival.

Then we will not have to organize you into soul-winning teams. When you leave the church service on Sunday, you will have one thing on your mind: find somebody and get them born again. Then nourish them to the baptism in the Holy Spirit, get them healed, and start them in training until they can come and train here.

That becomes your purpose. Your job and vocation still matter. Do a top-notch job, but do not let your ministry go. Get on somebody and work with them until you get them into the Kingdom. When they are doing what you are doing, go get somebody else. When they drop out of church, go get them.

And do not be so depressing that you have to have a cheerleader to get you to serve God.

"You do not understand my problem."

I know. It is bigger than God, and you are the first person who has ever come in here with problems God cannot take care of. If God is worried about your problem, then you have a good reason to worry. But if He is not worried about it, you are wasting your time.

There is a place in Him. In closing, I wish I could take a spiritual Holy Ghost knife, cut your spirit open, and put peace in. I cannot. I wish I could take that same knife, cut you open, and put the love of God in there. I wish I could open you up and put the understanding of righteousness in there.

These are great mysteries held in God. But I can introduce you to a Gentleman. He is the third Person in the Godhead. I can introduce you to Him, and if you will do what He says and start praying in tongues, you will speak mysteries. Pretty soon God will respond and answer those mysteries, and He will turn you over to Jesus. Jesus is all of these things: the hope of glory.

What you could not even fathom with your carnal mind will come alive in you. He is all these things. It is at this level that transformation to His Word takes place.

So in the basics of prayer, I would say: pray in tongues, fast, and search for God with all your heart. Let Him purge you from the sins of the flesh. Put off the old man. Stop your lying. Stop your complacency. Stop your indifference. Turn yourself over to the Holy Ghost, and He will use you.

For many things I have revealed to you, seeing some of you are slow of hearing and dull in insight.

Oh, that you would allow Me to fellowship with you by My mighty Holy Spirit, for He is My power. He is My might. I would edify and build you up into places of My Spirit where I could anoint your eyes to see many of the things that have held you in bondage.

They will turn loose. I will set you free.

Stay consistent, says the Spirit of grace, and in your thinking give Me first place. I will pick you up and anoint you with understanding from on high. I will show you through the power of My Spirit how to have the old man die.

I will give you peace beyond compare, the kind of joy that when you enter into My presence, you find Me there.

So My children, why worry? Why walk in fear? Prepare yourself. Pray in the Spirit, and I will draw near.

Oh, that you would hear. That you would hear what the Spirit says to the Church.